



KMPlayer

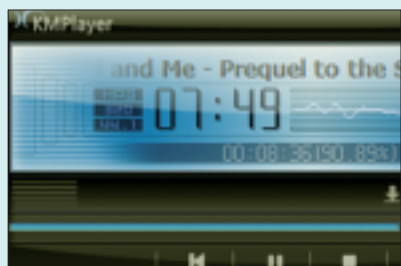
A 30 minute exploration into KMPlayer—the underdog of free media players

Rossi Fernandes

KMPlayer has been around and it is well known for being an alternative for viewing media in place of Windows Media Player that comes bundled with every Windows operating system. There are other alternatives but they are either too simple or too slow because they too many features. KMPlayer finds itself in between these two. It is also free and can be downloaded from www.kmplayer.com. You can find it in this month's CD/DVD.

Switching Quality And Performance Presets

Almost all of the media we view has been compressed to keep the file size small and in this process there is some visible quality loss. While some users would like to use enhancements to improve this, there are always some who need the best performance because of their slower computers. There are presets that can be enabled which can either lower system resource consumption and some which can improve quality. These presets can be enabled by right clicking on the interface and then on Video (Advanced). You can choose from Preset: Speed, Normal and Quality.



KMPlayer has all the necessary features for being a dedicated audio player

Using KMPlayer as a music player

Like any other media player, KMPlayer can also play audio files of all kinds. When you drag and drop a music folder into KMPlayer, it immediately transforms its interface to something similar like Winamp.

Loading Winamp Plugins Into KMPlayer

KMPlayer can even also pick up Winamp plugins and skins from the Winamp folder. This means you can use visualizations and other effects plugins in KMPlayer without having to sacrifice anything.

Open KMPlayer's Preferences window by right clicking on the KMPlayer interface and clicking on Options > Preferences. Click on Plugins. Here you can choose on the type of plugins you want to use—Input, Audio and Video DSP, Visualizations, and so on. Click on the button next to the mentioned path and select the one with the Winamp plugins—\Program Files\Winamp\Plugins. The Winamp plugins should be visible in the list. To change the settings for any of them, click on them and click Setup.

Selecting Decoders For Formats

There are times when we might want KMPlayer to handle all the formats and codecs by itself. Some users may have bought commercial decoders and would want to use that. KMPlayer gives easy access and allows users to change decoders for all kinds of formats. Click on Preferences and then on Filter Control. Click on Internal Video Decoder and then uncheck the codecs and formats you don't want KMPlayer to handle, then click on External Video Decoder and select the ones you want to use from the dropdown menus. External decoders not visible can be added by clicking on the External Decoder Search button. Repeat the same steps for the audio formats.

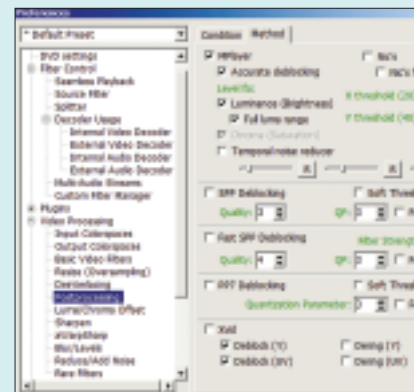
Turning On Image Quality Enhancements

We have talked about enhancements that people like using to improve the image quality in videos. All the filters available can be configured by starting KMPlayer's Preferences window and then clicking on Video Processing. Enabling and disabling of these filters can be done quickly by right clicking on the KMPlayer window and then on the filter of your choice under the Video (Advanced) submenu.

One of the filters worth enable is post processing which has the deblocking features in it. It must be said this is a very CPU intensive filter but its main purpose is reducing pixilation in videos of very low resolutions and quality playing on a larger screen. There are similar features for audio such as normalisation and resampling of tracks.

Colour Correction

Very few monitors give you the perfect colour so some amount of colour adjustments might be required. The adjustments can be made by clicking on Colour Controls in the Preferences window. You can choose from a hardware or software colour correction technique. Once that is done, you can make changes to the colours levels, saturation, brightness, contrast and gamma.



Deblocking is one useful feature that can reduce visibility of pixilation

Capturing Audio And Video

KMPlayer can grab screenshots like any other advanced media player but it can also grab audio and video tracks. This is done by right clicking on the KMPlayer window and then on Capture. Here you can choose to capture screenshots, audio or video. Advanced features such as setting up the codec for encoding while capturing is also available but that requires a pretty high end system. There's even a feature that allows you to create a storyboard out of a video.■

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This will scan the current mailbox for any deleted mail but are still present unseen and deletes them permanently.

Connect And Disconnect Automatically

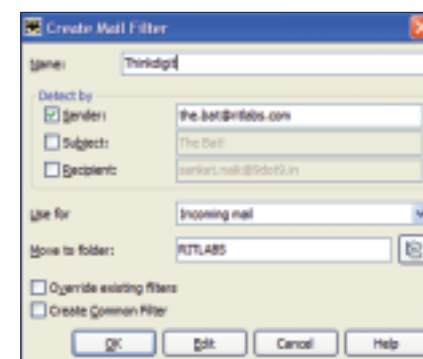
Not everyone is online 24 hours receiving mail, especially when you are charged by usage time. Connecting to the Internet automatically to retrieve mail and disconnecting when the messages are downloaded is one useful feature provided by Bat! to configure this feature follow the steps given below.

1. From the menu, select Options and then click on Network & Administration.
2. Select Dial-up networking connection and in the dropdown box select the dial-up connection you want the Bat! to use.
3. Tick the checkbox Auto-disconnect after mail transmission and click OK.

Creating A Message Filter From An E-mail

The Bat! has probably the most versatile and powerful messaging filter of all clients and it can be used to automate most mundane tasks. This tip will allow you to create a filter from an e-mail.

1. Click and select the message you want to use as the template for creating the filter.
2. From the menu, select Specials and then click on Create filter.
3. Specify a name for the filter, and then use the criteria on which the message has to be detected, that is, sender, subject and recipient.
4. Select when you want the filter to be applied, that is, Incoming mail, outgoing mail, etc.
5. Select the folder where you want the message to be moved. Click OK to complete the change.

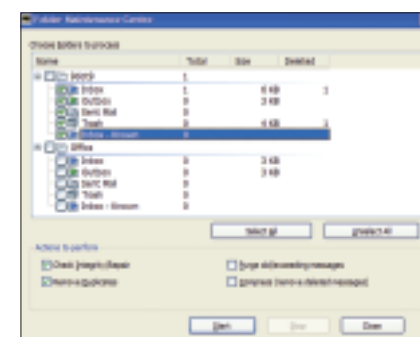


Setting filters is also easy

Perform Folder Maintenance

Folder maintenance refers to routine cleaning and fixing of mail folders which needs to be done to ensure Bat! runs smoothly. Bat! has its Folder Maintenance Centre built-in, which can perform some pre-defined checks and tasks.

1. From the main menu, go to Folder>Maintenance centre, which opens a page with options.
2. On the page that opens all mail folders from various accounts are listed, select the one on which you have to perform the maintenance task.
3. In the Actions to perform, tick all the four checkboxes and click on start. Once done click on Close.



Fixing errors automatically

Reply Without Quoting The Original Message

Sometimes you need to reply to a message without quoting the original message. We often select and delete the message, but Bat! offers a simple solution for this.

1. Select the message you want to reply without quoting the original message by opening it in its window.
2. Select Specials from the menu and click on Reply Without Quotation and that should do it.

MOZILLA THUNDERBIRD

The free e-mail client from the makers of Firefox makes an excellent choice for homes and personal use. Here are few tips to make a pro at using it.

Access IMAP Email Inbox Offline

IMAP's flexibility can be extended by making it available offline. This feature comes handy where you are travelling to a place with no Internet access and would need access to you mail. For this you need to tell

Thunderbird to make your inbox to be made available offline.

1. Go to Tools>Account Settings and go to the desired IMAP account
2. Select the Offline & Desk Space category and make sure Make the messages in my inbox available when I am working offline is checked. Click OK.
3. To go offline, go to File>Offline and then select Download/Sync Now.
4. Make sure Mail messages is selected under Download / Sync the following:, also check Work offline once download/sync is complete. Click OK.

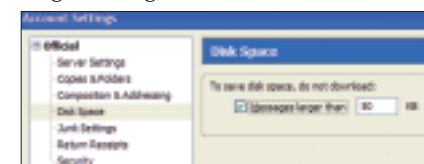
Adding Senders Quickly To The Address Book

A dirty, but quick way of building your e-mail Address book is to add e-mail address from their e-mail directly. Mozilla Thunderbird allows doing so in just two mouse clicks, here's how:

1. Open any e-mails you have received and look out for the From: header.
2. Right-click of the highlighted name or e-mail address and from the context menu that appears select Add to Address book.
3. Edit the card and enter other relevant information.
4. Click on OK, to save the changes done to the card.

Avoid Downloading Large Messages

If you are on dial-up or slow Internet connection, it is advisable to leave a large message on the server and save



Save time—download only headers

your POP account from getting stuck. Once configured, Thunderbird will truncate large message and will get just the header. If you want to read the full message you can do so later by using the link inserted at the end of truncated message.

1. Go to Tools>Account Settings.
2. Go to Disk Space sub-category of the e-mail account.
3. Make sure Do Not download messages locally that are larger than is selected.
4. Enter a maximum value for the message size. Default is 50 KB, you can increase it as per your liking. Click OK to save the changes.